

SMASH SHIFT From France and Korea to India and Japan, challengers are closing the gap on Dragon Nation

CHINESE BADMINTON'S FADING AURA

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For generations, China did not just produce badminton champions but opponents who could make a match feel almost over before it began. The aura around Zhang Ning, Xie Xingfang, Lin Dan and Chen Long was as important as their titles, because there always seemed to be another Chinese player ready to take over. That aura has begun to fade and China's return from the recently concluded BWF World Championships in New Delhi offered perhaps the clearest evidence yet. China won only one of the five gold medals, through Liang Weikeng and Wang Chang in men's doubles, while France and South Korea won two apiece. More significantly, China had no finalist in either singles event, with their men's singles campaign ending in the opening round when India's Ayush Shetty stunned world No. 1 and defending champion Shi Yuqi. Yet to call it the end of Chinese badminton would be premature. Wang Zhiyi can still win major titles -- as she did at this year's All England -- Yuqi remains the world's leading men's singles player and China's doubles combinations continue to be the strongest in the sport. At the Paris Olympics in 2024, China won two of the five badminton gold medals, in women's doubles and mixed doubles, besides three silver medals. Since badminton became an official Olympic sport in 1992, China have won 22 golds and 52 medals overall. The question, then, is not whether China are still strong but whether they are still the feared rival they once were. Former India international Trupti Murgunde, who faced several Chinese players during her career, has noticed the change. "It's definitely not what it used to be. At the World Championships, we didn't have any Chinese players on the podium in men's singles, and none in the women's singles final. Apart from the paired events, they weren't really anywhere. In my era, players like Zhang Ning and Xie Xingfang dominated; if they entered a tournament, a win was almost guaranteed. Now, even

against top Chinese players, a victory isn't a given anymore. Women's singles has opened up completely with top talent coming from many different countries," Murgunde told DHOs. That fear factor was built over decades. Modern racquet badminton arrived in China in the early 20th century through expatriate clubs and foreign communities in cities such as Shanghai, Tianjin and Beijing before spreading among students and urban communities. After 1949, the sport was systematically developed, national competitions began in the 1950s and overseas Chinese players and coaches, particularly those with links to Indonesia, helped raise technical standards. So when China entered the unified international badminton system in 1981, they already had a strong domestic culture and an organised sporting structure and the impact on the international stage was immediate. At the 1982 All England quarterfinals, seven of the eight women's singles players were Chinese, while former champion Lene Koppen was the only outsider. Dinesh Khanna, the 1965 Asian champion, remembers how far ahead China appeared physically and technically. "In women's singles, they completely dominated. At the 1982 All England quarterfinals, seven of the eight players were Chinese, and they easily thrashed the single non-Chinese player, former champion Lene Koppen. Their fitness levels and centralised training regimens were completely ahead of the rest of the world," Khanna said. China then defeated Indonesia 5-4 in a gruelling nine-match final to win the 1982 Thomas Cup on debut and followed it by winning the Uber Cup at their first attempt in 1984. The country soon became a dominant force at the World Championships and other major events as well. What made that rise so difficult to stop was the depth behind it as badminton was not merely an elite sport in China; it was woven into everyday life, played in schools, workplaces, parks and clubs. With recreational participation estimated in the hundreds of millions, the country had an

enormous pool from which to identify talent. At the elite level, players moved through a structured pathway from schools and local programmes to provincial teams and eventually the national setup. Jiangsu, Zhejiang, Fujian, Hubei and Guangdong became major talent-producing regions, giving the national system a steady supply of players. The names that followed explain China's dominance as Gong Zhichao, Zhang Ning, Xie Xingfang, Wang Yihan and Li Xuerui formed a succession that made Chinese representation at the top of women's singles almost routine through the 2000s and early 2010s. Lin Dan and Chen Long carried the same authority in men's singles while doubles produced stars such as Ge Fei, Gu Jun, Gao Ling, Zhang Nan, Zhao Yunlei, Fu Haifeng and Cai Yun. For years, particularly in women's singles and doubles, China appeared to have an answer for every challenge. Now the rest of the world has caught up. The professionalisation of badminton has played a major role as prize money has increased, national programmes have become better resourced and players from countries that once struggled to match China's training environment can now work with coaches, fitness specialists, analysts and sports-science teams. "Chinese dominance has definitely reduced. The game has become

far more professional with higher prize money, which incentivises players globally to train seriously. Historically, China relied on centralised, government-supported training camps while players from other countries lacked backing. Today, other nations like France and Denmark train scientifically and travel with full support staff," Khanna said. The result is a much more competitive field. In women's singles, South Korea's An Se-young has become a dominant force, Japan's Akane Yamaguchi has repeatedly challenged the Chinese hierarchy and Chinese Taipei's Tai Tzu-ying spent years showing that Chinese opponents could be out-thought as well as outplayed. PV Sindhu also enjoyed sustained success against Chinese opposition. Men's singles has become even less predictable, with several players capable of beating one another on their day. Shetty's victory over Yuqi in New Delhi was perhaps the clearest example. France's Alex Lanier then went on to win the world title, showing how far the competitive landscape has shifted. "Shi Yuqi is around 30 and currently not at his peak due to lean periods. Opponents are not intimidated by him as Ayush even pulled off an upset against him in the first round. While players can maintain performance into their early 30s, strong contenders are actively challenging and defeating him," Khanna said.

Murgunde felt Shetty's approach was just as important as the result. "Ayush was exceptionally well-prepared and played without fear. Yuqi can be a slow starter in the initial rounds of a tournament, and Ayush capitalised on that. He dominated early, played smart tactics, and didn't allow Yuqi to dictate the pace of the game," she said. Even China's traditional strength in women's doubles offered a similar warning in New Delhi. Liu Shengshu and Tan Ning had looked almost invincible on their way to the final, with their attacking game and reported smash speeds approaching 400kmph making them one of the tournament's most imposing pairs. Yet South Korea's Baek Hana and Lee So-hee neutralised that threat and won in straight games. For Murgunde, the change is also tied to how badminton itself has evolved. "The transition to the 21-point rally system made the game much faster and shortened rallies overall. Players from other countries have also caught up significantly in fitness and training clarity. Skill-wise, I feel past Chinese players were more skillful in deception and stroke play. Today, long rallies aren't just a Chinese strength; you see them across all top nations, especially in women's doubles," she said.

That is why China's performance in New Delhi should not be read as an obituary for Chinese badminton. The country has not fallen out of the elite; they have simply lost their monopoly.



Duke Of Tuscany wins feature race

PUNE RESULTS
Pesi Shroff-trained Duke Of Tuscany, ridden by jockey Ajinkya, won the Idar Gold Trophy, the main event of the races on Saturday.
1. Azzuro Plate - 1200M: Challenge Accepted (Ramswarup) 1, Manor House (S G Prasad) 2, Son Of A Gun (A Prakash) 3, Liban (Aditya Waydande) 4. WB: 5 1/2, 1 3/4, 9. T: 1:38.25. TB: A Jodha. Fav: Challenge Accepted.
2. J E Hughes Trophy - 1600M: Sovereign King (Antony Raj) 1, Chagall (Vivek G) 2, Fighton (P Dhebe) 3, Regina Memorabilis (Neeraj Rawal) 4. WB: 1/2, 1 3/4, 9. T: 1:38.25. TB: A Jodha. Fav: Sovereign King.
3. Evaldo Plate - 1600M: Seneca (Ramswarup) 1, Don Julio (Neeraj Rawal) 2, Spanish Eyes (P Trevor) 3, Ashwa Gypsy (Haridas Gore) 4. WB: 1 1/4, 1 1/4, 1. T: 1:39.20. TB: A Jodha. Fav: Don Julio.
4. Star Trainer Plate - 1000M: Darcy (C Umesh) 1, Admirable (Neeraj Rawal) 2, Storm Cloud (Avinash Paswan) 3, Gunfire (Yash Narredu) 4. WB: 2 1/2, 1 1/4, 1. T: 57.65. TB: Faisla Abbas. Fav: Gunfire.
5. Noshir & Dolly Dhumjibhoy Sprint - 1200M: Encino (P Trevor) 1, Shambala (Antony Raj) 2, Market King (Vivek G) 3, Social Butterfly (Neeraj Rawal) 4. WB: 2 1/2, 2 1/4, 1 1/4. T: 1:08.21. TB: A Jodha. Fav: Encino.
6. Idar Trophy - 2400M: Duke Of Tuscany (Ajinkya) 2, Fynbos (Vivek G) 2, King's Gambit (Yash Narredu) 3, Dream Alliance (Neeraj Rawal) 4. WB: 3/4, 1 3/4, 1. T: 2:29.34. TB: P Shroff. Fav: Fynbos.
7. Fourth Estate Trophy - 1400M: Esteban (Avinash Paswan) 1, Funny Bunny (Vivek G) 2, Believe (Ajinkya) 3, Appalachian (T S Jodha) 4. WB: 2 3/4, Lnk Snk. T: 1:25.97. TB: N Lagad. Fav: Funny Bunny.
8. Capitulate Plate - 2000M: Exotic Star (S Mosin) 1, Whisper (Vishal) 2, Ma Cherie (Haridas Gore) 3, Okinayume (T S Jodha) 4. WB: 2 1/4, 2 1/2, 2 1/4. T: 2:10.61. TB: S Waheed. Fav: Mai Tai.
Mysuru dividends
I race: Total: Rs 15 (w) 10, 12p; Shp: Rs 30; Thp: Rs 37; Fc: Rs 26; Q: Rs 27; Tri: Rs 190 & 139.
II race: Total: Rs 13 (w) 10, 16p; Shp: Rs 29; Thp: Rs 30; Fc: Rs 22; Q: Rs 29; Tri: Rs 65 & 64.
III race: Total: Rs 34 (w) 22, 10p; Shp: Rs 27; Thp: Rs 32; Fc: Rs 124; Q: Rs 83; Tri: Rs 216 & 121.
IV race: Total: Rs 40 (w) 20, 17, 30p; Shp: Rs 37; Thp: Rs 81; Fc: Rs 205; Q: Rs 88; Tri: Rs 2550 & 1750.
V race: Total: Rs 16 (w) 10, 14p; Shp: Rs 20; Thp: Rs 31; Fc: Rs 31; Q: Rs 16; Tri: Rs 193 & 188.
VI race: Total: Rs 66 (w) 19, 10p; Shp: Rs 47; Thp: Rs 44; Fc: Rs 217; Q: Rs 61; Tri: Rs 302 & 388.
VII race: Total: Rs 69 (w) 26, 11, 37p; Shp: Rs 38; Thp: Rs 126; Fc: Rs 343; Q: Rs 117; Tri: Rs 3704 & 4763.
VIII race: Total: Rs 35 (w) 16, 10p; Shp: Rs 26; Thp: Rs 22; Fc: Rs 163; Q: Rs 68; Tri: Rs 213 & 125.
Jackpot: Rs 1,90,043 & 6787. **Mini jackpot:** Rs 25,412. **I treble:** Rs 229. **II treble:** Rs 1700.

India to face Korea in opener
NEW DELHI, PTI: Led by midfielder Khaidem Shileima Chanu, the Indian women's hockey team will open its campaign against South Korea in the AHF Women's Junior Asia Cup, to be held in Moqi, China, from September 4 to 13.

HOCKEY WOMEN'S WORLD CUP

Argentina end Dutch title reign

Belgium secure historic bronze to end a 28-year wait for medal

Argentina dethroned three-time defending champions The Netherlands by prevailing 3-1 in the penalty shootout of the title encounter at the Waganer Stadium after the match ended 1-1 in regulation time. In the bronze medal playoff, joint-hosts Belgium posted a facile 1-0 victory over former champions Australia. The all-important goal in the contest came from a penalty corner conversion by Charlotte Englebert. The Argentine players leapt in joy and got into a big embrace when Sofia Cairo scored with her shootout attempt to give the South Americans a winning lead with one attempt remaining for both sides. This was Argentina's third World Cup triumph, coming 16 years after their 2010 triumph over the same rivals.

Moonveil for main event
HYDERABAD SELECTIONS
S S Attallaah-trained Moonveil, to be ridden by jockey P Trevor, is fancied to win the Coronandil Gromor Deccan Fillies Championship (Grade - III) - 1600M, the feature event of the races on Sunday. The first race starts at 1:35 pm.
1. Carter Princess Plate - 1800M: Mandate 1, Theos 2, Orionvale 3.
2. Belmont Prince Plate - 1800M: Lysia 1, Tipped Off 2, Concordia 3.
3. Bhagyanaagar Million - 1400M: African Gold 1, Regal Reality 2, Echoes Of Time 3.
4. Director General Artillery Cup - 1100M: Live Legend 1, Timeless Elegance 2, Kantha 3.
5. Director General Of Police Trophy (Div I) - 1400M: Solara 1, Basilica 2, Stars Envied 3.
6. Coronandil Gromor Deccan Fillies Championship (Grade - III) - 1600M: Moonveil 1, Madante 2, Regal Beauty 3.
7. Director General Of Police Trophy (Div II) - 1400M: Knight Regent 1, Disciple 2, Foxy Girl 3.
Day's best: Solara. **Jackpot:** 3, 4, 5, 6 & 7. **I treble:** 2, 3 & 4. **II treble:** 5, 6 & 7.



All three Argentine titles — 2002, 2010 and 2026 — were clinched by defeating The Netherlands in the title encounter. Runners-up to the Netherlands at this venue itself in the 2022 World Cup, Argentina trailed after Yibbi Jansen's penalty corner goal for the Dutch until the 56th minute, when captain Maria Granatto flicked a penalty corner rebound to equalise and take the contest into the shootout. The most successful nation in women's World Cup history with nine titles in 52 years since the elite tournament began in 1974, The Netherlands are also the reigning Olympic gold medalists and were playing in their eighth successive final, looking to extend their title-winning spree to four. But on Saturday they ran into a robust and attacking Argentine outfit that created history of its own. The last time that The Netherlands failed to make it to the title contest was in 1994 at the Dublin World Cup. In all, The Dutch women have

made 14 appearances in the World Cup finals, winning nine of them. In comparison, the Argentines were playing in their seventh final. In the 2022 final, The Netherlands had won 3-1 against Argentina. The fast-paced encounter saw the ball frequently travel from one end of the pitch to the other. It was not until the 13th minute that Argentina, pressing hard and forcing all 11 Dutch players to fall back inside the 25-yard area, made the first foray into the circle.

Returning Alcaraz buzzing with confidence

NEW YORK, AFP: Carlos Alcaraz (impic) said on Friday he feels at "100 percent" ahead of his defence of the US Open, but acknowledged feeling anxious after a four-month layoff due to a wrist injury. "I need to come here to practice with these guys to feel the competition once again, and this is really testing," he said. "I'm feeling great and ... that helped me a lot to know right now that it's all in my head," he said. Alcaraz, 23, the youngest player to win the career Grand Slam after triumphing



in Australia in January, hasn't played singles since April 16, with withdrawing from the Barcelona Open with a right wrist injury and subsequently skipping both the French Open and Wimbledon. Alcaraz told reporters on Friday that his coaching and support team had complete confidence that he was ready to go. "I gotta trust my people that tell me that it's gonna be fine. So I just have to go 100 percent," he said. "So I'm just trying to to like stay away ... from that fear."



Karnataka's Sarthak Bhattarai (left) and Bengal's Hamidul Ali vie for the ball during the Junior National Football Championship on Saturday. DH PHOTO/ B K JANARDHAN

Late Munoz strike saves Liverpool the blushes

LONDON, AFP

Victor Munoz saved Andoni Iraola from his first defeat as Liverpool manager with the late strike that rescued a 2-2 draw against Nottingham Forest on Saturday, while Hull beat Coventry to extend their dream return to the Premier League. Forest were set to win at Anfield for the third consecutive season as Dan Noye and Morgan Gibbs-White's penalty twice put the visitors in front. Alexander Isak briefly brought Liverpool level in the second half before Munoz's deflected effort rescued a late point for the second time in Iraola's two matches in charge. "It's quite clear the first half has been poor, we haven't controlled the game," Iraola said. "We improved a lot in the second half, much more intense, much quicker on the ball but not enough to win the game." After a 2-2 draw at Newcastle in his first game as Liverpool boss last weekend, Iraola had hoped for a memorable day to mark his first match in charge at Anfield. But instead the former Bournemouth boss got a reminder of why he was hired to replace the sacked Arne Slot in the close-season.



Iraola could have Bradley Barcola to unleash by the time Liverpool are next in action at Ipswich on Friday. The France winger has been one of the Reds' top targets for months and a £106 million (\$144 million) deal with Paris Saint-Germain, which could rise by a further £17 million, is reportedly close to completion. "I cannot tell you anything right now. There are still things going on at this moment," Iraola said. "Now we have to wait and look forward to having the squad on September 2, when this is who we are and can work with certainties." Hull substitute Liam Millar struck in the closing stages to steal a 1-0 win at Coventry. Millar slotted home with eight minutes left as Hull won a battle between sides promoted from the Championship last term. Having stunned Manchester United with a 2-0 victory last weekend, Sergej Jakirovic's men have won both their matches in their first season in the top tier since 2016-17. Frank Lampard's Coventry won the Championship to end a 25-year exile from the Premier League, but they are still awaiting their first point back in the big time after losing their opener at Arsenal last week. James Tarkowski's stoppage-time equaliser earned Everton a 1-1 draw that left Marco Rose still waiting for his first win as Bournemouth manager. Alex Scott's 41st-minute goal put Bournemouth ahead at the Vitality Stadium. But Everton defender Tarkowski capitalised on a mix-up between Ryan Christie and Marcus Tavernier to drill home following a corner in the closing seconds. Everton remain unbeaten after a 2-0 win against Crystal Palace last weekend, while Bournemouth were beaten 2-1 at Manchester City in Rose's first game since replacing Iraola. **Results:** Liverpool: 2 (Isak 60th, Munoz 82nd) drew with Nottingham Forest: 2 (Noye 24th, Gibbs-White 70th P); Bournemouth: 1 (Scott 41) drew with Everton: 1 (Tarkowski 90+1); Coventry: 0 It to Hull: 1 (Millar 82nd).

The decisive moment came in the 67th minute when Suraj Gazi guided Suroj Halder's well-delivered cross into the net following a set-piece situation, giving Bengal a lead they defended until the final whistle. Karnataka had chances to take control much earlier. In the 38th minute, Sukham Nelson Singh came agonisingly close when his effort from outside the box struck the post. Minutes later, striker Sarthak Bhattarai was presented with another clear-cut opportunity but directed his shot straight at goalkeeper Arpan Mitra. Their best chance to rescue

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Karnataka's Junior Boys National Football Championship for Dr B C Roy Trophy campaign ended in frustration as they squandered a string of chances, including a late penalty, to go down 1-0 to West Bengal in their final Group B match of the Tier I competition at the BFS here on Saturday. With the winner assured of a semifinal berth, Karnataka needed only a draw to progress, but their inability to make their opportunities count proved costly.

Bengal break Karnataka's hearts

The campaign arrived in the 84th minute when Veda Janviri won the ball and made a solo run into the box, only to be brought down by Ayush Rajak. Dhruv Shyam, the hat-trick hero from Karnataka's previous match, stepped up for the penalty but saw his effort kept out by a diving Arpan. Karnataka, who were at the top of the table heading into the match, slid to the third spot to end their campaign as Punjab decimated neighbours Chandigarh 6-0 in the final group match later in the day. **Results:** Group B: Karnataka: 0 It to West Bengal: 1 (Suraj Gazi 67th); Punjab: 6 It Chandigarh: 0.